

THE BIG BANG



On the morning of May 18, 1974, in the Pokharan desert, the ground shook violently as India conducted its first atomic bomb test, cloaking it as a peaceful nuclear explosion. In doing so, India became the world's sixth nuclear power after the US, Soviet Union, Britain, France and China. The US took offence to India barging into the exclusive nuclear club angrily stating that India's test would seriously undermine the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty of 1968 and trigger an arms race in the sub-continent. The US then blocked aid to India and imposed numerous sanctions.

FIRST CUT

- The first tripartite meeting between India, Pakistan and Bangladesh was conducted in Delhi.
- India's first lion safari park was opened in Hyderabad.

<< DID YOU KNOW

India topped the list of US wheat buyers, with cash orders for 3.8 million tonne and another 3 lakh tonne expected to be delivered under the food-for-peace aid programme.

SINKING FEELING

Cause: The nation faced a food shortage of 8 million tonne and prices were up by 25

per cent. Effect: Indira Gandhi cracked down on striking workers.

